ER OON Operating Model 2027: Models A, B and C

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Summary

All three models keep 10 full-cycle teams in Lebanon, the same levels and badges, and meet the January 1, 2027 deadline, when the IDR Gateway becomes US-only. They differ in how Gateway filing is done.

- **Model A (people-first):** a 7-person US desk types prepared disputes into the Gateway from ClickUp tickets, in about 47 minutes each.
- **Model B (automation-first):** Lebanon sends ready-to-file bundles, and a 3-person US desk files them through a form-filling Submission Cockpit, in a target of 10 minutes.
- **Model C (guided copy desk, proposed):** Lebanon prepares each dispute in the IDR Prep Studio, which mirrors the Gateway page by page and checks every field. A 5-person US desk copies each field into the Gateway with one-click copy buttons and submits it, in a target of 15 minutes.

Against Model A, Model C saves **$94,000–114,000 a year** today and **$328,000–400,000 a year** by year two. That is about 60–75% of Model B's saving, without new software or a Gateway approval beyond the onshore rule. No model includes recruiting fees or infrastructure costs: we recruit in-house and run on systems and equipment we already have.

Recommendation: propose Model C. It is ready for January 1 with tools we already have, needs no Gateway approval beyond the onshore rule, keeps a 5-person desk that absorbs absences, and captures most of the saving. Model B stays the long-term option once the Gateway confirms in writing that assisted form filling is allowed.

At a glance

Model B wins on cost and speed, and Model A on simplicity. Model C is the middle ground: ready on January 1 like Model A, with most of Model B's saving.

	Model A: people-first	Model B: automation-first	Model C: guided copy desk (proposed)
How filing works	US desk types from ClickUp tickets	A Cockpit form filler fills the Gateway; the operator checks and submits	The US desk copies each field from the IDR Prep Studio and submits; no tool touches the Gateway
Time per dispute	About 47 minutes	Target of 10 minutes	Target of 15 minutes
US desk today	7: 1 working lead, 6 associates	3: 1 Submission Lead, 2 Specialists	5: 1 lead, 4 associates, in two staggered shifts covering 07:00–19:00 Central
US desk in year 1 / year 2	12 / 18	5 / 7	8 / 11
US desk cost today	$346,000–421,000	$192,000–244,000	$252,000–307,000
Ready for January 1	Yes	No; runs on Model A's desk until Gate 2 (April 30, 2027)	Yes; the Studio is built and used in the December parallel run
Outside approvals	Legal sign-off on the onshore rule	Also written Gateway confirmation that assisted form filling is allowed	Legal sign-off on the onshore rule only
Absence cover	One absence removes 1 of 7	One absence removes 1 of 3	One absence removes 1 of 5
New software	None	Submission Cockpit and form filler	None; the IDR Prep Studio already exists
Lebanon specialists by year two	About 125	About 102 (AI drafting)	About 125; can add AI drafting later
Main risk	Cost grows with volume	Gateway terms; a 3-person desk	Copy errors

	Model A: people-first	Model B: automation-first	Model C: guided copy desk (proposed)
Lebanon structure	10 teams, 94 people, bridge night rota	Same, plus a 2-person Automation Cell	Same as Model A

Model A: people-first

Model A replaces 12 facility teams with 10 full-cycle teams and moves Gateway entry to a 7-person US desk that types from ClickUp tickets. Lebanon prepares every dispute; the US desk only enters it. The team structure, levels, badges, transition and bridge night rota described here are shared by all three models.

- **One owner per account:** each RCM Specialist works an account from coding to final payment, replacing the coder, biller and negotiator handoffs.
- **Payer portfolios, not facilities:** work is balanced by effort in three tiers, and new facilities join existing teams.
- **US Gateway Desk:** 1 working lead and 6 associates enter prepared ClickUp tickets and make no pricing decisions.
- **Bridge night rota:** any L2, L3 or L4 holding B2 can opt in. Two members work 16:00–24:00 Beirut each night and share a $30,000 quarterly pool, at $300–3,000 each.
- **Careers:** L0 Junior RCM Specialist, L1 RCM Specialist I, L2 RCM Specialist II, L3 Senior Specialist I and L4 Senior Specialist II, earned through 15 skill badges (C Core, B Specialist, A Advanced) in quarterly test windows. L1 and L2 are automatic once the badges are held; L3, L4 and L5 need a leveling test. L5 Principal is the leadership level for team leads and managers. Every December the top 10% of each level earn their missing badges.
- **Transition and standards:** the top 10% of each role earn their role badges without tests, everyone else tests within 3 months, and the bottom 10% restart at L1. Missing badges for the confirmed level are earned by December 31, 2027. No one's pay goes down. From December 2027, losing 25% of badges at a semiannual review means probation, and 50% means termination.
- **Growth:** the US desk scales on a backlog trigger, to about 12 people in year one and 18 in year two.

Model B: automation-first

Model B keeps Model A's teams, levels and badges, and cuts the US desk to 3 by sending it ready-to-file bundles instead of tickets.

- **Submission Cockpit:** a US operator opens a bundle on a company device, a helper fills the Gateway forms, and the operator checks every field and clicks submit personally. It is built in-house on our existing Google Workspace, starting from the IDR Prep Studio.
- **Dispute factory in Lebanon:** AI drafts packets, medical-necessity reports and offer letters, and specialists approve them. The target is 0.33 specialists per daily visit instead of 0.45.
- **Automation Cell:** 2 Automation Analysts from current specialists own the templates and AI prompts, and the bridge night rota runs the final bundle check.
- **12-hour US day:** three staggered shifts cover 7:00–19:00 Central, so work prepared in Lebanon is filed the same day.
- **Compliance guardrail:** only a US person on a US device acts in the Gateway. There is no mirroring, remote control or unattended submission.

Model C: guided copy desk (proposed)

Model C keeps Model A's teams, levels and badges, and makes US filing faster and safer with a tool we already have, the IDR Prep Studio. No automation ever touches the Gateway.

- **IDR Prep Studio:** an internal web app on our Google Workspace that mirrors the Gateway page by page, including multiple line-item pages. Lebanon enters every field there, the Studio checks formats and required documents, and it saves a confirmation PDF of the summary page.
- **Copy desk:** the US operator opens the dispute in the Studio's copy desk, which lists every value in portal order with a Copy button, in the format the Gateway expects. The operator copies each field, uploads the documents, and submits personally.
- **15 minutes per dispute:** typing, look-ups and format errors disappear, and the operator only copies, checks and submits.
- **5-person US desk:** 1 lead and 4 associates in two staggered shifts covering 07:00–19:00 Central. Two more associates on 3–6 month contracts cover the cutover until Gate C1 on March 15, 2027.
- **Compliance:** only a US person acts in the Gateway, so only the onshore rule needs legal sign-off.

- **Path to Model B:** if the Gateway later confirms that assisted form filling is allowed, the Cockpit can be added on top of the Studio.

Cost comparison

Model C costs about **$94,000–114,000 a year less** than Model A today, and **$328,000–400,000 less** by year two. Model B saves more, but carries the approval and technology risk. US figures are approximate Texas market rates for direct hires, plus 25% for benefits and payroll taxes; replace them with our own pay offers. No recruiting fees or infrastructure costs are included.

Annual cost (USD)	Model A	Model B	Model C (proposed)	Model C saves vs A
US desk today	7 people: 346,000–421,000	3 people plus AI drafting: 192,000–244,000	5 people: 252,000–307,000	94,000–114,000
Year 1 (about 4,400 disputes a month)	12 people: 580,000–707,000	5 people plus AI drafting: 302,000–374,000	8 people: 393,000–478,000	187,000–229,000
Year 2 (about 6,500 disputes a month)	18 people: 861,000–1,050,000	7 people plus AI drafting: 412,000–504,000	11 people: 533,000–650,000	328,000–400,000
One-time	Paid onboarding: 58,000–70,000	Same onboarding, plus legal review of the Cockpit (quote needed)	Onboarding 42,000–51,000, plus 2 contract associates to March 15: 35,000–43,000	—

Lebanon, all models: the bridge night rota costs up to $120,000 a year from its $30,000 quarterly pool. Model B's AI drafting is targeted to avoid about 23 hires by year two, worth roughly $380,000 a year.

Advantages and drawbacks

Model A is the simplest way to meet January 1, and Model B the cheapest way to run once it is proven. Model C combines Model A's readiness with most of Model B's saving.

Model A: people-first

Advantages

- Ready for January 1 with no new software: ClickUp tickets and the deadline engine are all it needs.
- A 7-person US desk absorbs absences, leave and volume spikes.
- Simple to explain and run; the US role is plain data entry and easy to hire for.
- Lower compliance exposure, since only legal sign-off on the onshore rule is needed.
- Pay changes are modest and predictable.

Drawbacks

- Highest running cost, growing almost in step with volume to $861,000–1,050,000 a year by year two.
- About 47 minutes of manual typing per dispute, with more room for entry errors.
- US desk size depends heavily on whether the Gateway allows bulk upload.
- About 23 more Lebanon hires by year two than Model B.

Model B: automation-first

Advantages

- Saves $154,000–177,000 a year now and $449,000–546,000 by year two, and the gap widens with volume.
- Filing drops to a target of 10 minutes per dispute, and a 12-hour US day files Lebanon's work the same day.
- Two checks before filing: Bundle QA reviews every bundle, and the operator checks every field.
- AI drafting and the determination reader cut Lebanon workload and hiring.
- Builds on the IDR Prep Studio and systems we already own, so the up-front cost is small.

Drawbacks

- Depends on the Gateway's terms allowing assisted form filling; without it, most of the US saving disappears.
- A 3-person desk is fragile: one absence removes a third of capacity.
- New software to maintain, and Gateway screen changes can break its field mappings.
- AI drafts need constant specialist review and QA sampling.
- More change for staff at once, on top of the team restructure.

Model C: guided copy desk (proposed)

Advantages

- Ready for January 1 with a tool that is already built and tested, the IDR Prep Studio.
- Saves $94,000–114,000 a year now and $328,000–400,000 by year two against Model A.
- Only the onshore rule needs sign-off; no Gateway approval is needed, because a US person enters every field.
- The Studio checks every field and document before the US desk sees the dispute, so errors are caught in Lebanon.
- A 5-person desk covers 12 US hours a day and absorbs an absence.
- Leaves the door open to Model B's Cockpit later, without rework.

Drawbacks

- Saves less than Model B: about 60–75% of its saving.
- Manual copying can still introduce errors, so it needs a per-field checklist and night rota review.
- Lebanon spends some extra time entering disputes in the Studio, offset by fewer rejected tickets.

Risks

Model A carries mainly volume and people risks, Model B adds technology, approval and concentration risks, and Model C adds a copy-accuracy risk that its tooling controls. The people risks of the new levels and standards apply to every model.

Risk	Model	Likelihood	Impact	Response
We misread the Gateway's onshore rule	All	Low	High	Legal sign-off before the build; offshore access stays as a fallback until December 19
People see the new levels and tests as a threat	All	Medium	Medium	Top 10% earn badges without tests, protected pay, published criteria, one appeal each, consequences only from December 2027
The badge-loss termination rule is challenged	All	Medium	High	HR and legal review under Lebanese labor law before publication; documented reviews; one appeal
We lose IDR experts during the change	All	Medium	High	Early, open communication and a Senior Specialist path that doesn't require managing
The US desk falls behind as volume grows	A, C	Medium	High	Backlog trigger adds staff within 2 weeks; under C, 2 contract staff stay until Gate C1
Copy errors between the Studio and the Gateway	C	Medium	Medium	Studio validation, a per-field checklist and night rota review; errors under 0.5% at Gate C1
One US absence cuts capacity by a third	B	High	High	2 trained on-call staff, leave rules, kill switch on backlog
Gateway terms forbid the form filler	B	Medium	High	Gate 0 checks first; fall back to Model C
AI drafts contain errors	B	Medium	High	A specialist approves every draft; QA samples AI output weekly

Risk	Model	Likelihood	Impact	Response
A Gateway screen change breaks the Cockpit	B	Medium	Medium	Analysts fix mappings within 1 day; manual entry is always available

Recommendation and decisions

Go live on Model C. It meets January 1 with tools we already have, and every step can be reversed toward Model A staffing. Model B stays an option for later.

1. **October–December 2026:** hire 5 permanent US staff and 2 on 3–6 month contracts in-house. Get legal sign-off on the onshore rule. Train the desk and the bridge night rota on the IDR Prep Studio.
2. **December 2026:** parallel run in the Studio at 25%, then 50%, then all Gateway work; full cutover on December 19. Rank every member within their role on 2026 KPIs.
3. **January 1, 2027:** the Gateway goes US-only, filed from the Studio by the Model C desk.
4. **January–March 2027:** transition tests; the 10 teams launch.
5. **Gate C1, March 15:** 15 minutes or less per dispute, errors under 0.5% and no missed deadlines for 4 weeks. The contracts end and the desk runs at 5.
6. **April 1:** new levels take effect, with raises for anyone moving up.
7. **Later, optional:** if the Gateway confirms in writing that assisted form filling is allowed, pilot Model B's Cockpit on top of the Studio and follow Model B's gates.

Kill switches: we add staff back toward Model A's size if any of these happens:

- The backlog stays above 1 business day for 5 days in a row.
- A deadline is missed because of the desk or a copy error.
- Errors stay above 1% for 2 weeks.

The contract staff can be extended, and in-house recruiting keeps a bench of pre-screened candidates, so more people can start within 2 weeks. Manual entry from ClickUp tickets always stays available.

Decisions requested:

- [ ] Approve Model C: a 5-person US desk filing from the IDR Prep Studio, plus 2 contract staff until Gate C1, hired in-house from October.
- [ ] Approve the legal review of the onshore rule.

- [ ] Approve the shared levels, badges, transition plan and bridge night rota, as set in the Badges, Levels and Transition appendix.
- [ ] Keep Model B as a later option, to be considered only after the Gateway confirms in writing that assisted filling is allowed.